

MAGNUS OPUS

The Norwegian genius showcased his **unparalleled mastery** of the game, clinching both the rapid and blitz titles in dominating fashion.

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Magnus Carlsen once described chess in three words: "I am him."
Was he being arrogant? Overconfident? Was it just a casual flex after winning a minor tournament? No.
For Carlsen, it was pure honesty — a statement of fact from a man who, in his own words, has arguably "completed" chess.

With five Classical World Championships, four Rapid titles, and six Blitz Championships, Carlsen's accolades are unparalleled. Add to them his triumphs at the Candidates Tournament, the World Cup, the Sinquefeld Cup, Norway Chess, and Tata Steel Chess, among hundreds of others, and the list of achievements feels endless.

For someone who once admitted to finding chess "boring," what keeps him motivated to continue and remain the best? "I like to play chess. It's my favourite hobby in the world," he said with a sheepish smile, his words belying the relentless dominance he exhibits on the board.

"It's very satisfying that I can still be quite good, especially against the younger generation. For me, that's motivation enough in itself. Coming to each new event, it's like I've never won anything before."

At the Tata Steel Chess India 2024, Carlsen's passion for the game was evident as he secured both the rapid and blitz titles, claiming victories with a round to spare.

Carlsen's slow start to the tournament proved to be an illusionary prelude. After drawing his first two games in the rapid round against R. Praggnanandhaa and Nihal Sarin, the Norwegian maestro unleashed a six-game winning streak, crushing opponents one after another.

Of all his victories, Carlsen singled out his sixth-round triumph over Arjun Erigaisi as his personal favourite. Playing with black pieces, he employed a rare line of the Taimanov Sicilian, demonstrating exceptional positional understanding and tactical awareness to outmanoeuvre the young Indian star.

"Arjun is an extremely dangerous player when he has the initiative and gets to attack. I willingly got into a position where he had the initiative, and while my play wasn't perfect, I'm very happy I

Top class: Magnus Carlsen with the winners of the blitz and rapid sections in the women's section — Kateryna Lagno and Aleksandra Goryachkina (L-R). PICS. DEBASISH BHADURI

